And further, I made it clear that there would be zero tolerance for custodial deaths or other unlawful acts that sometime took place at the hands of the forces. I also directed that the term 'kill' would not be used while reporting about terrorists killed in actions or operations conducted by our troops. These operations are not like the hunting expeditions during the Raj period, where, at the end of the day, asking the question, 'How many "kills" did you have?' was the norm.

WikiLeaks documents released in London and Delhi on 16 December 2010 make a mention of a secret briefing of US diplomats by the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) in 2005. While describing some forms of ill-treatment and torture of detainees, the briefing said 'that the situation in Kashmir was "much better" as security forces no longer roused entire villages in the middle of the night and detained inhabitants indiscriminately, and there was "more openness" from medical doctors and the police.' In the same cable, American diplomats approvingly quoted media reports that 'India's army chief, Lieutenant (*sic*) General Joginder Jaswant Singh, had "put human rights issues at the centre of a (recent) conference of army commanders."'[1]

Use of force happens when the security forces are severely provoked and in an adverse situation, and consequently under great stress. If we drop a bomb on a village to kill two terrorists, and instead, destroy a house with twenty innocent civilians, including women and children, the result will be the creation of twenty families of sworn enemies! One has read of such mistakes having taken place in Afghanistan and Iraq.

Despite these steps, some mistakes are invariably committed by the troops on the ground. We couldn't afford to have any more cases that happened before I took charge – such as that of Manorama Devi, who was alleged to have been raped and killed by the security forces in 2004 in Manipur. These charges were denied and it was claimed that she was shot while trying to escape, but the army's version drew flak from some media and human rights activists. There was also the case of Major Rehman, who was accused of rape in Kashmir. Such incidents take the government and the security